

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examination 2014

CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: **THREE** hours

Candidates are permitted to bring into the examination room paper dictionaries (with the title in English).

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions in total: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B**, and **ONE** from either **SECTION A** or **SECTION B**.

The paper consists of **seventeen** questions in total: ten in Section A and seven in Section B.

All questions are of equal weight.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator.
Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.
Do not open the question paper until told to do so.
All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.
All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.
At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

SECTION A

Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B, and one from either Section A or Section B.

1. What can the philosophical position of empiricism offer sociology? Are there any problems involved in this approach?
2. Outline and assess the key arguments used by neo-Kantian thinkers in challenging positivism.
3. Critical Realists recognise both that societal structures form an external reality which exists independently of human knowledge of them and that humans have an impact on how they affect us. Reconstruct the main arguments behind this position, and discuss its implications for the nature of our knowledge about the world.
4. Identify the shared premises which inform the approach of Berger & Luckmann, as well as Garfinkel, in terms of phenomenological sociology; next, identify their distinct theoretical and research concerns.
5. Outline and assess the main points of agreement and disagreement between Popper and Kuhn regarding the development of the natural sciences.
6. How has Actor-Network-Theory challenged traditional sociological approaches to the study of science?
7. What are the benefits and limitations of using “women’s experience” as a tool for sociological research?
8. What is feminist standpoint epistemology? Why is it important?
9. “One ever feels his [sic] twoness” (Du Bois). Outline and assess Du Bois’ key arguments regarding “race”.
10. How and why have some post-colonial theorists criticised the distinction between “the West” and “the Rest”?

END OF SECTION A

SECTION B

Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B, and one from either Section A or Section B.

11. “It is not that power is good or bad but, rather, it is dangerous.” Critically assess this statement by Foucault.
12. According to Foucault, how are the knowledge, governance, health and wealth of national populaces interrelated?
13. What is distinctive about Bourdieu’s approach to understanding contemporary social inequality? How useful are his concepts?
14. According to Barthes, what are the links between myths, signs and ideology?
15. What is modern about modernity?
16. Outline and assess the postmodernist argument that signifiers are more real than “reality”.
17. It is generally agreed that we face a growing global ecological crisis. If so, why is so little being done to avert it?

END OF SECTION B

END OF PAPER SC301-6-FY